Treat 32-bit float as extra insurance, not permission to stop listening.

Record every speaker separately

Whenever possible, give each person their own microphone and track. If two hosts share one microphone, every adjustment affects both voices. Separate tracks allow you to raise a quiet guest, reduce a loud host, remove one person's cough while the other speaks, and process voices differently during editing.

For an in-person two-person recording:

- **Step 1:** Connect one microphone per speaker.
- **Step 2:** Route each microphone to a separate mono track.
- **Step 3:** Set gain separately because different voices produce different levels.
- **Step 4:** Ask speakers to keep roughly the same mouth-to-mic distance throughout.
- **Step 5:** Monitor both tracks through headphones.
- **Step 6:** Make a short test in which speakers talk individually and then briefly overlap.

Keep microphones physically separated and aimed carefully to reduce bleed from the other speaker. Do not worry about eliminating bleed completely; prioritise clear direct speech.

Record remote interviews locally

For important remote interviews, prefer a recording workflow that captures each participant locally and then uploads the individual tracks. Riverside's technical documentation, for example, defines a participant track as the local recording of that individual.

Even with such software, build redundancy.

Before the interview, ask the guest to wear headphones, close unnecessary applications, sit in a quiet furnished room and keep the microphone close.

Then follow this workflow:

- **Step 1:** Join ten minutes early and check the guest's microphone selection.
- **Step 2:** Ask them to disable notifications and plug the laptop into power.
- **Step 3:** Confirm that headphones are being used so your voice does not return through their speakers.
- **Step 4:** Record separate local tracks through your chosen platform.
- **Step 5:** For a high-value interview, ask the guest to make an additional local recording on a phone or recorder placed close to them.
- **Step 6:** Do not close the session immediately after the conversation if the platform is still uploading local files.

The extra phone recording may never be used. Its purpose is to save the interview on the day you desperately need it.

Recording outdoors

Outdoor recording introduces wind, vehicles, crowds and unpredictable interruptions. Choose microphone placement before worrying about scenery.

Use a lavalier close to the speaker or a directional microphone positioned as close as framing permits. A proper windscreen is essential when air is moving; a thin indoor foam cover may not be enough in stronger wind.

Scout the location before the guest arrives. Listen for generators, announcements, railway lines and recurring traffic. Moving even a short distance behind a wall or building can reduce noise.

For handheld recorders, 32-bit float can provide useful protection against sudden changes in level, but continue monitoring whenever practical. Zoom specifically positions the technology as useful when unexpected level spikes occur during field recording.

TROUBLESHOOT THE MOST COMMON PROBLEMS

- **Echo:** Move closer to the microphone and add soft material around the recording area.
- **Ceiling fan or AC rumble:** Move the microphone away from the airflow, use the microphone's rejection pattern intelligently, and try a low-cut filter only after fixing placement.
- **Electrical hum:** Disconnect unnecessary chargers and test devices one at a time. Keep audio cables away from power adapters where practical.
- **Plosives:** Move slightly off-axis and use a pop filter.

What you need to do

Set up the actual space you intend to use for your podcast and record a two-minute test containing normal speech, loud speech, laughter and ten seconds of silence.

Listen through headphones first, then through your phone speaker. Score the test from one to five for voice clarity, background noise, echo, plosives and level consistency. Fix the lowest-scoring category and repeat the test.

Finally, perform a deliberate failure drill: unplug the primary recording device or stop the main software and confirm that your backup is genuinely recording.

Clean audio is rarely the result of an expensive rescue in post-production. It is the result of small decisions made before and during recording: move closer, listen carefully, leave headroom, isolate speakers, record separate tracks and always make a backup. Once those habits become automatic, your recording setup becomes reliable enough that you can stop thinking about it—and concentrate on the conversation. d